

2.3 Unit 2, Option A: Early Modern British History: Crown and Authority

Focus

Grounded in an understanding of the relevant chronology, this option concentrates on key developments in early modern British history with particular emphasis on an understanding in some depth of the exercise of power and influence in English society, including the authority of English monarchs, the roles of Parliament and the Church, and attitudes to key developments through the period. It also gives students the opportunity to understand the diplomatic, religious and financial factors which affected both the growth, and the practical limits of, royal power in early modern English society.

Clarification of content for each topic can be found in *Appendix 1*.

Students entered for Option A are required to study ONE topic: A1 or A2.

A1 Henry VIII: Authority, Nation and Religion, 1509-40

- Henry VIII and the quest for international influence: relations with France, Scotland and Spain.
- The structure of government: the role of Wolsey to 1529 and his relations with King, nobility and Parliament.
- Henry's changing relations with the Catholic Church and the break with Rome; the role of Parliament in the early stages of the Reformation; the roles of Cranmer and Cromwell.
- The Dissolution of the Monasteries: support for, and opposition to, religious change from 1529.

A2 Crown, Parliament and Authority in England, 1588-1629

- The war with Spain, 1588-1604: course of and impact on both Government and English society; extent to which late Elizabethan England was in crisis.
- Early Stuart foreign policy: relations with France, Spain and the Austrian Habsburgs
- The financial difficulties of the Crown: reasons for and attempts to resolve them.
- Changing relations between the Crown and Parliament: implications for the authority of the Crown and the extent to which the influence of Parliament grew.